

- RAG Learning

2.7 US Pressure Groups

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 2 (Government and Politics of the USA and Comparative Politics)

Pressure groups are considerably more powerful in the USA than in the UK. The reason is **institutional, not cultural**: the separation of powers and federalism create far more access points, weak party discipline makes individual legislators genuinely persuadable, and an entrenched constitution makes litigation a route to permanent change.

1. Constitutional foundation

Group activity has explicit constitutional protection. The **First Amendment** guarantees freedom of speech, assembly and the right "to petition the Government for a redress of grievances". This matters analytically: it means group activity cannot simply be regulated away, and — after *Citizens United* — that restricting group political spending is treated as restricting speech.

2. Types of group

Type	Description	Examples
Interest / sectional	Represent an occupational or economic section	American Medical Association; AFL-CIO; US Chamber of Commerce
Promotional / cause	Campaign for a cause, open membership	Sierra Club; ACLU; NAACP
Single-issue	Focused on one question, often with intensely committed members	National Rifle Association; National Right to Life

Membership / demographic	Represent a large demographic bloc	AARP (older Americans)
Policy / think tanks	Research organisations shaping the agenda	Heritage Foundation; Brookings Institution; Cato Institute

3. Methods

Lobbying

Direct persuasion of members of Congress, **congressional staff** and federal agencies — often including supplying draft legislative language. This is the most consistently effective method because it operates at the drafting stage, and because Congress's own research capacity has declined relative to the complexity of what it regulates. Federal law requires lobbyists to register and disclose clients and expenditure.

Electioneering

The distinctively American method, with no real UK equivalent:

- **PACs** donate directly to candidates within statutory limits.
- **Super PACs** spend unlimited sums on independent advocacy.
- **Scorecards** rating legislators' voting records, mobilising single-issue voters.
- **Primary funding** — the sharpest weapon, since it threatens a legislator's renomination.

Exam Tip: The **NRA's historic effectiveness** rested less on total spending than on a membership that would vote on *that issue alone* in primaries. Combined with scorecards, this made opposing it genuinely dangerous to a Republican legislator's career. Intensity of preference, channelled through primaries, beats raw numbers — and no UK group has an equivalent lever, because the UK has no primaries.

Litigation

- Bringing carefully selected **test cases** with sympathetic facts.

- Filing **amicus curiae** briefs in cases brought by others.
- The **NAACP Legal Defense Fund**'s long-term strategy culminating in *Brown v Board of Education* (1954) is the classic example — achieving through the courts what a Congress dependent on southern Democratic votes would never have delivered.

Grassroots mobilisation and direct action

Generating constituent contact, demonstrations and media attention. This is the principal recourse of groups without money, and it can defeat better-funded opponents where public feeling is intense — the campaign against the 2017 ACA repeal is a good example. Well-resourced groups increasingly **manufacture** the appearance of grassroots support ("astroturfing").

4. Why US groups are so powerful

Factor	Mechanism
Multiple access points	Separation of powers means a bill must pass the House, the Senate, survive the filibuster, be signed and survive judicial review. Federalism adds fifty state governments. A group needs to succeed at only <i>one</i> veto point to block
Weak party discipline	Legislators are nominated in primaries and fund their own campaigns, so they vote independently. Persuading or funding <i>one</i> member can change an outcome
Candidate-centred, expensive elections	Legislators are structurally dependent on continuous fundraising
Entrenched, enforceable rights	Litigation can deliver permanent nationwide change beyond legislative reversal
Federalism	Many decisive powers — education, policing, elections, abortion — rest with states, which are cheaper to influence

Exam Tip: An important qualification most answers miss: **many access points also mean many veto points**. US groups are therefore better at *blocking* than at *achieving* — they must win at every stage but need only prevail at one to stop something. A UK group that persuades a government with a secure majority can see its aim legislated in full. "More powerful" depends on whether the group wants change or its prevention.

5. Iron triangles and the revolving door

Iron triangle — a stable, mutually beneficial relationship between a congressional committee, a federal agency and an interest group. The group supplies funding, expertise and political support; the committee supplies favourable legislation, appropriations and sympathetic oversight; the agency supplies favourable implementation.

The arrangement **insulates a policy area from wider scrutiny**, since all three participants benefit from the status quo. Defence procurement and agriculture are the standard examples. The model fits some areas far better than others: **issue networks** in contested fields such as healthcare and the environment are far more open and competitive.

The **revolving door** — movement of officials and members into lobbying and industry roles — gives firms privileged access and inside knowledge, and creates incentives for officials to favour future employers while still in office. Federal cooling-off periods exist but are widely regarded as easily circumvented.

6. Pluralism vs elitism

Pluralist view (Dahl)	Elitist view (Mills)
Power is dispersed; any interest that organises can compete	Policy is shaped by a small, well-resourced elite drawn from corporate, military and political leadership
The many access points ensure no group dominates every arena	Influence follows money, organisation and access — not numbers

Government arbitrates between competing demands	Diffuse public interests are consistently defeated by concentrated private ones
Groups supply expertise and continuous representation	Iron triangles and the revolving door entrench insider access

Assessment: group competition is genuine and outcomes frequently reflect compromise, which pluralism predicts. But the competition is plainly unequal, since pluralism assumes rough parity of access and business enjoys **structural leverage** — governments depend on investment and employment decisions — that no membership campaign can match. The usual resolution is that the system is *pluralist in form but elitist in effect*.

7. Do groups help or harm US democracy?

Help

- Continuous representation between elections; intense minorities get heard.
- Supply legislators with expertise Congress increasingly lacks.
- Multiple access points mean defeat in one arena is not final.
- Mobilise and educate citizens; scrutinise implementation through litigation.

Harm

- **Influence tracks resources, not numbers** — inverting the democratic principle. Post-*Citizens United* dark money conceals who is funding political messaging.
- **Iron triangles and the revolving door** place whole policy areas beyond effective public scrutiny.
- **Unaccountable** — groups are not elected and bear no responsibility for consequences.

Exam Tip: The most sophisticated criticism is not that groups wield power illegitimately — elected officials make the decisions and remain removable. It is that the **fragmentation of the American system makes it impossible for voters to identify who is responsible** for

an outcome. The accountability failure lies in the institutional design that makes group influence so effective.

Key terms

Term	Definition
PAC	Committee donating directly to candidates, subject to limits
Super PAC	Committee spending unlimited sums independently, barred from coordinating with campaigns
Dark money	Political spending whose donors need not be disclosed (501(c)(4) groups)
Iron triangle	Stable alliance of committee, agency and interest group in a policy area
Issue network	A looser, more open and competitive set of actors in a contested policy area
Revolving door	Movement of personnel between government and lobbying or industry
Amicus curiae brief	Submission to a court by a party not directly involved
Astroturfing	Manufacturing the appearance of grassroots support
Structural power	Influence arising from government dependence on business investment and employment
Scorecard	Group rating of legislators' voting records, used to mobilise single-issue voters

Essential examples

- **NAACP and *Brown* (1954)** — litigation delivering what legislation could not.
- **NRA scorecards and primary funding** — intensity of preference beating numbers.

- ***Citizens United* (2010)** — Super PACs and the surge in outside spending.
- **ACA repeal defeat (2017)** — grassroots mobilisation defeating a better-funded effort.
- **AARP** — a demographic bloc that makes entitlement reform politically near-impossible.
- **ALEC** — model legislation supplied to under-resourced state legislatures.